

VertiGO!!!



Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 724 December 2009 PO BOX 1628 WELLINGTON



Mayan Smith-Gobat at Ceuse.

Image from Mayan's blog, <http://mayangobat.wordpress.com/>

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea & coffee afterwards. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 pm and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up.



Next section night: 7 December 2009

When impossible forces meet immovable objects – Mayan Smith-Gobat

Mayan will talk about her recent experiences climbing in Europe and Yosemite.



Mayan Smith-Gobat at Ceuse.
Image from Mayan's blog, <http://mayangobat.wordpress.com/>

summer rock 10

9 feb - 27 march

introduction to

climbing techniques

leading on bolted routes,

belay and seconding multi-pitch

two weekends in wellington at baring head
and at titahi bay plus two weekends away at
wharepapa south and whanganui bay, taupo

2010 course cost \$550.00



wharepapa



wharepapa



turakirae head



railay beach thailand



mt arapiles australia



darrens fiordland



whanganui bay



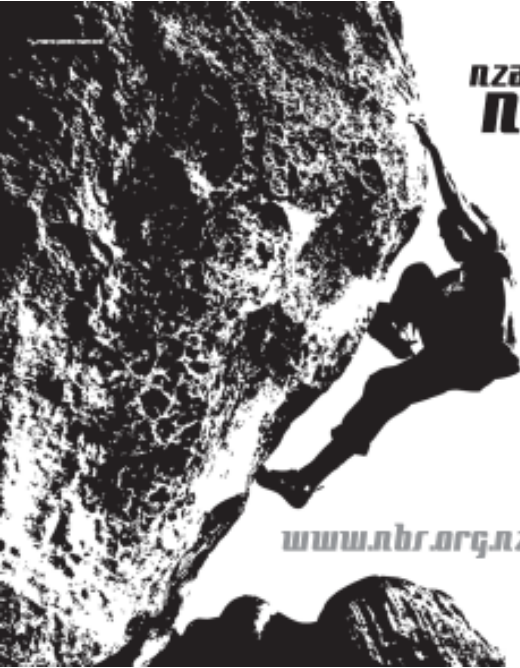
mt arapiles australia

www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

No previous experience is necessary. The course is also an excellent refresher
check the web for more information about the course

Contact: bh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

mt arapiles australia



nzag national bouldering series 2010

WAITOMO 13 FEBRUARY
BARING HEAD 20 FEBRUARY
JARDINES 6 MARCH
SPITTLE HILL 13 MARCH

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METOLIUS LA SPORTIVA NEW ZEALAND ALPINE CLUB

**The 2010 Baring Head Rock Hop will be held on
20 February (cancellation day 21 February)**

Further information is at www.nbs.org.nz

**Volunteers are required to make this event
a success – please contact Scott Miller
(email Scott.Miller@Transact.co.nz) for details**



TRIP REPORTS

Please send your trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.

Arapiles International Club Trip Report

In the last week of October 2009 the Wellington section of the NZAC undertook its first official overseas club trip in five years. Lead by Kevin Patterson and accompanied by Steve Hutchison, over a seven day period we successfully completed 24 routes involving 55 pitches at Mt Arapiles in western Victoria (Australia).

And what a trip it was. We arrived on Saturday night to a strong cool southerly which saw the locals shivering, clustered together as we enjoyed lovely New Zealand like weather – 17C.

Two days later it was the locals turn to laugh as a couple of Kiwis ended up as burnt omelets on the local features as temperatures soared into the low 30s. We were forced to retreat to the local pool where we regrouped with a strategy which suited our mutual strengths – 5am alpine starts! Followed by 10am breakfasts (Steve, put the coffee on thanks – let them know where we're from – lol), and then siestas till 4pm. Then climb on into the evenings. We camped all week in "The Pines" which was well shaded and had several long-term residents. Such was the heat that on the last day one climber had to be choppered off half way up the Tiger Wall with heatstroke. All this in October where average daily maximums are usually in the 20-25C range.

The routes at Arapiles are superb and challenging multi-pitch adventures often soaring a 100m or more above the Wimmera Plains. Overhangs abound, as do cracks and chimneys and caves. The rock is 500 million year old, beautiful, red, metamorphosed sandstone. This rock is very solid and easy to safely place trad gear.

The grading is however on the high side and very inconsistent, particularly for the classics, which reflects the fact that most were put up in the mid-60s (the Ewbank grading system only started in 1967). As a rough rule of thumb we found we had to add 2-4 to the grade number to make them consistent to what has been commonly graded since 1990.

Our adventures started with a straightforward five pitch warm-up (Eskimo Nell [10]). Day 2 was the classic The Bard (12), called such by the original ascensionists who quoted Shakespeare to each other on their first ascent. The Watchtower Chimney (12) in the afternoon had a scary, long first pitch (more like an 18), and then some beautiful chimneying moves in the shade. Day 3 got serious with Lamplighter (14) in the shade followed by The Rack (18) which was an extreme overhanging vertical hand jam crack (more like a 21).

Wednesday was a biggie with five routes sent starting with Resignation (15) which had a very exposed, run out third pitch which is guaranteed to fix any constipation issues! And finishing with Agamemnon (11) a lovely shaded chimney adjacent to Muldoon (another

classic). Thursday was pretty cruisy, The Green Singer (14) was very straightforward and was also the longest route we had done yet (120m). On Friday we worked the organ pipes, with Cantata (18) and Crescendo (17) being challenging climbs. Steve then cruised D Major (9) in jandals! Even this climb was overhanging – not bad for a 9! Then rain in the form of a brief thunderstorm called the end of play in the late afternoon.



Kev on Eskimo Nell

Friday night was also party night as the campground numbers swelled from 20-30 to more than 200 at the start of the long Melbourne Cup weekend. Empty LPG stove gas canisters were blown up all night as partying went into the wee hours.

On Saturday came our ultimate climb – The Watchtower Crack (16) - this route had intimidated us all week. Four pitches, with some potentially long layback sections – the route guide read “The most commanding line at Arapiles still echoes with the whimpering cries of a thousand struggling leaders. Psyched for a 200’ layback...”, “Unquestionably John Fahey’s finest hour; the rest of the party swarmed up the rope after him like drowning rats” lol – except we weren’t laughing! The first pitch Steve lead was a hard to protect steep slab which he worked well. I did the second which was quite reachy but easy to protect. By then we were 50m up and the sun was rising sharply – it was getting warm. The third pitch Steve lead was only 18m but had a difficult roof to get around which he eventually did by carefully traversing out using tenuous holds on the exposed face, the ground falling away 70m below, before returning back to the crack. The last pitch I lead (32m) was undoubtedly my finest hour! The crack started vertically then curved overhead forcing my layback into an undercling. The inside of the crack was damp and slippery and my heart must have been doing 200 bpm as I moved up and underneath struggling to maintain smearing pressure on the face. Everything in my vision

narrowed to the few square cm's in front of my face such that I missed seeing half the holds available – lol. Eventually the slope eased and just under three hours after starting we topped out.



Watchtower crack

We couldn't leave without having a look at Mitre rock and a number of ascents were completed including the legendary West Ridge (grade 1, the guide said "watch out for those dead climbers, fixed ropes and oxygen bottles") which was completed as a challenging descent.

I would rate the Arapiles very worthwhile, and while expensive for a rock climbing trip (we spent ca. NZ\$1000 each which included car hire [\$21/day] plus five sit down dinners) most of this was airfares. Whilst airfares were the most expensive part of this trip (ca. \$500pp), there is a trend for these to reduce as competition increase on the trans-tasman routes. Easter may be a better time to go however re heat and insects. However generally you can guarantee better weather than any Labour Weekend climbing trip I've ever been on in NZ.

Climbers – Kevin Patterson and Steve Hutchison

South Face of Douglas

Veteran Wellington Section member Dave Bamford climbed the South Face of Douglas in late October. Dave and alpine guide Sam Bosshard of Twizel, struck excellent ice conditions on the left hand gully. Good conditions meant that the pair reached the summit by midday after 13 pitches. The absence of “dinner plating” ice on the climb was great. It was Dave’s 10th attempt on the route over 30 years.

Jon Taylor and Ryan Lobb from Invercargill also climbed the same route but had to dodge the ice from the team above! Erin Hawke and Rod Barker from DOC Fox Glacier also had excellent conditions in the central gullies. Poor snow on the descent of Douglas and Glacier Peak meant that the parties had a long slog back to the Pioneer Hut.



Hot sun, cool looking goggle tan (not!)

Wellington section members Richard Davies, Kieran Paton, Graham Bussell and Hannah McGregor, along with some other riff-raff in the form of Ben Clark and Ben Clendon met up with CNI member Eric Duggan for some ski touring and exploring on the summit plateau. Based out of a large igloo/tent encampment between Cathedral Rocks and Te Heuheu the Whangaehu and Whakapapa were skied, Pare was ascended before a return to the Bruce Rd via the Mangaturuturu and the slopes below Pare. Sunny all weekend. Lobster all round.



Ice trippin' with the Canty-Westlanders

Over Show Weekend in November, I joined the Canterbury-Westland Section for their biannual "Whack'n'Dangle Weekend" at the Fox Glacier. We got in two full days of climbing on the lower Fox, which also included some practice at leading, a bit of crevasse jumping, ice caving, and even some overhang action! It was my first time on a glacier and I was initially a little bit jumpy about being willingly lowered into a crevasse, but it soon started to feel sort of normal.

The Glacier was a great place to explore and to try and get the hang of 'the triangle' (although bridging can work too). While I had to field one or two 'curious inquiries' as to what passed for mountains in the North Island, the South Islanders were generally pretty nice to me, and only threatened to cut the rope a couple of times a day.

Of course, you're never too far away from home when you're climbing, and, while at Porter Lodge, I also enjoyed bumping into some Wellington Sectioners, who had just returned from blunting their tools on Mt Lendenfeld. It was a great trip and I am looking forward to trying some ice climbing when Ruapehu is in season next year, and tagging along with the Canty-Westlanders (a great bunch of people) again.

Lorraine Johns



Avoiding the overhang (photo by Clayton Garbes)

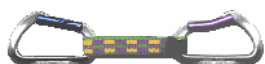


UPCOMING CLUB TRIPS



Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the Wellington Section. Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going. Send your trip ideas, no matter how vague, to trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Annual NZAC Climbing Camp, Matukituki Valley

Date: 2 – 9 January 2010

This years Climbing Camp will be in the Matukituki Valley adjacent to Aspiring Hut, from Saturday 2nd January to Saturday 9th January 2010. It will be hosted by the Otago Section and is a fantastic opportunity for climbers and their families to gather in the mountains for climbing, tramping and generally have fun. There is some fantastic climbing in the area; from the easy peaks of Tyndal and Ansted above Cascade saddle to the many climbs accessible from Colin Todd and French Ridge huts, including Mt Aspiring, Mt French and Mt Avalanche.

See NZAC website for details <http://alpineclub.org.nz/default/377>). Contact Kevin at 934 0975 (evenings) or email me at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz for carpooling arrangements.



Colin Todd Hut underneath the NW ridge of Aspiring



Paynes Ford / Pohara

Date: 22 – 25 January 2010

Leader: ShiChang Hou

Level: Rock grade 15-30

Come spend the long anniversary weekend in 'hippie-ville'. Golden Bay hosts two of the finest limestone crags with long mid-range routes at Pohara and hard classics at Paynes Ford. There is something here for everyone including beaches with white hot sand at Pohara and extensive cool swimming holes adjacent to the Hang Dog campground at Paynes. Relax afterwards with a meal of mussels and Guinness while watching the cricket at the Pohara Pub. Contact ShiChang at sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Nikki on the Pohara cliffs



Mangaokewa

Date: 26-28 February 2010

Leader: Steve Minchin

Level: Rock grade 18-30

Come sample the steepness! Mangaokewa offers overhanging sport climbing, with 70 routes mostly in the 18-23 range - this probably isn't a trip for absolute beginners but it should be a good weekend away for those who climb like monkeys... The crag is just out of Te Kuiti and offers free camping, flush toilets, BBQ pits, and a river, so it should be a great place to hang out if the weather is nice. If the weather is rubbish then no worries - the cliffs are overhanging so if you want to stay dry, you'd better keep climbing. Contact Steve at 021 127 3925 or email sm@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Wharepapa South

Date: 12-14 March 2010

Leader: TBA

Level: Rock grade 12-25

Outstanding chance to climb on a wide variety of mid-graded ignimbrite (volcanic rock). An exciting mix of bolted and trad routes 55km south of Hamilton. We'll plan to camp in the area leaving Wellington after work on Friday. Contact Kevin at 934 0975 or by email at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Arrowsmiths from the Lawrence

Date: 1-5 April 2010 (Easter weekend)

Leader: TBA

Level: AIC Graduate and 0-3 years experience

Chance to use some of those lazy last days of the autumn before the first of the snows come in. Walk in will be from Erewhon. The rock is better on western side of the Arrowsmith range. Friday High Camp, Saturday Summit, Sunday Spare Day, Monday Walk Out, Tuesday drive home. There exists the potential for doing a new rock route so bring your cams! Contact Kevin at 027 687 9573 or by email at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Whanganui Bay

Date: 23-25 April 2010

Leader: TBA

Level: Rock grade 16-25+

Come join us for a weekend of sport and trad climbing at Whanganui Bay. Plan is to leave Wellington after work on Friday evening and tent for 2 nights at the Bay. With over 1000 routes to choose on classic ignimbrite rock adjacent to the beautiful Lake Taupo from this is truly the Mecca of North Island rock climbing. Try yourself out on the Whakenui classics of Small Pocks (19, sport), James Stirling Direct (17, trad), and the three pitch chimney climb Tibia (16, trad). Contact Kevin at 934 0975 or by email at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Kawakawa Bay

Date: 7-9 May 2010

Leader: TBA

Level: Rock grade 13-22+

Take a trip to the newly developed crags of nearby Kawakawa Bay. Come along for a weekend of sport (and some trad) climbing on some quality rock, against the backdrop of the largest lake in the North Island. Explore the large number of mid-grade climbs available including the classic 2 pitch High Hopes (16). Hone up on those rock skills with some full pitch climbs. Contact Kevin at 934 0975 or by email at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Mt Tapuae-o-Uenuku

Date: 4-7 June 2010 (Queen's Birthday weekend)

Leader: TBA

Level: AIC Graduate and 0-3 years experience

Opening alpine snow trip for the winter season! Come climb the second highest peak in NZ outside the Mt Cook area. This was one of Hillary's early climbs back in the 1940's, except instead of doing it in 1 day like Sir Ed did we'll take 3! On Friday night we'll take the ferry and stay near the road end. Saturday will be the trip in up the Hodder River to stay at the Hodder Huts – some 66 crossings! On Sunday we'll attempt a summit via the traditional north ridge. No ropes required. Contact Kevin at 934 0975 or by email at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Ruapehu South

Date: 9-11 July 2010

Leader: TBA

Level: AIC Graduate and 0-3 years experience

On Friday night we will drive up to Ohakune and either tent near the mountain road or stay at the backpackers. Saturday we will ascend the highest point on Ruapehu = Taurangi peak (2797m) returning for a pub meal at the Powderhorn in the evening. On Sunday we will attempt Girdlestone (2658m), the outlying peak on the right of Taurangi by crossing the Mangaehuehu Glacier. Contact Kevin at 934 0975 (evenings) or email me at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.



NOTICES



Waikato Tramping Club 60th Birthday Celebrations

We invite past members to join us to celebrate our 60th birthday on 15-16 May 2010. Please send your contact details to us and the contact details of any other past members you know.

Waikato Tramping Club 60th
PO Box 685
Hamilton 3240
Email: wtc60th@paradise.net.nz
Website: www.wtc.org.nz



Visiting American climber

I am a member of the American Alpine Club, and will be travelling to NZ in November 2009 – February 2010. I'd like to hook up with NZAC members to find partners for alpine and trad climbing. I'll be focusing on the Otago and Canterbury areas, roughly Queenstown up to Arthur's Pass, and maybe a bit in the Darrans.

Cheers, Mike (zarmot@yahoo.com)



Member discount – Ramset tru-bolts



Ramset are now offering NZAC members a 65% discount on 10 and 12mm stainless steel tru-bolts at all their stores, nationwide. To view a list of outlets visit their website: www.ramset.co.nz/trade_centres.html



Auditor wanted

After sterling service Paul Clarke has stepped aside as auditor of the Wellington Section's accounts, so we are looking for someone to help out. If you are interested, or know of someone who might be, drop a line to treasurer@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



NZAC Alpine Calendar



A very limited stock of 2010 NZAC Alpine Calendars is now available. This is the first truly New Zealand Alpine Club calendar, as it has been printed using winning images from the Club's 2009 Photo Competition. Due to very limited stock, this is initially being offered to members via newsletters before becoming available online. Cost is \$25 for members (\$30 non members). Postage \$2 within NZ, \$2.50 to Australia, or \$3.00 rest of world – each. Please email Margaret@alpineclub.org.nz regarding purchases.



Mt Aspiring Photo Competition

Enter your favourite photo of Mt Aspiring / Tititea in the NZAC Photo competition to celebrate the Centenary of the First Ascent of Mount Aspiring / Tititea and you may win yourself \$500 worth of climbing equipment from Mainland Tramping in Wanaka!

The photos can be a landscape or nature shot, or can include an activity involving the mountain, like skiing or climbing.

- First prize: Mainly Tramping voucher for \$500 worth of climbing equipment.
- Second prize: Department of Conservation (Wanaka) book voucher worth \$50.
- Third prize: NZAC new updated 'Mt Aspiring Region: Guide for Mountaineers', worth \$25.

Check out the NZAC website for specifics. <http://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2009/photographic-competition-to-celebrate-the-first-ascent-of-mount-aspiringtititea>

Either email your entry to Pat: pat@alpineclub.org.nz or send a CD to Photo Competition, NZAC, PO Box 786, Christchurch 8140



High Alpine Skills Course, 1-5 February 2010

The New Zealand Alpine Club is running a High Alpine Skills Course for those NZAC members' who have participated on a Basic Instruction Course or instructed in a trainee capacity. The course will run for five days from 1-5 February 2010 and will be based at Mt Cook. Instructors will be qualified NZMGA Mountain Guides. The 'chief' guide will be Ray Button.

The course will cover the topics:

- Snow skills- use of crampons and ice-axe
- Glacier travel and crevasse rescue
- Pitched climbing on rock and snow
- Soft snow anchors
- Rock anchors
- Basic ice-screw anchors
- Route assessment and avalanche evaluation
- Basic navigation
- Alpine bivvying/ camping
- Basic weather assessment

The course is aimed at those who want to advance their skills and become more self sufficient as climbers. The course will be based on foot, rather than utilising helicopter or fixed wing access. It will also be 'bivvy' based rather than 'hut' based. This will keep the cost low and hopefully instil a 'walk-in' ethic in the participants. However, it does mean it is important participants have a good level of fitness.

The cost of the course is \$600. Additionally, participants will provide their own transport and food and pay their accommodation at Unwin.

If you are interested in the participating on this course, complete the application form on the NZAC website: <http://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2009/nzac-high-alpine-skill-course-mt-cook> or contact Pat at National Office (email pat@alpineclub.org.nz, phone 03 337 7595).



Whanganui Bay

On behalf of the club I would like to thank Mere for looking after and making the climbers feel welcome at Whanganui Bay all these years. Mere has passed the baton on to Carmen and Peter who are now the people to see when camping or climbing at Whanganui Bay. If you need to contact Carmen about the bay you can call / text her on 027 656 4505. Carmen's batch is the green one with the flag and sign outside it. The road in is a bit of rough condition at the moment, but we got our 2wd car down and out (just).

Again thanks to Mere for all your time.

Safe climbing.

Blair



Climbing, walking, or ski mountaineering in Europe in 2010?

The Club is considering trialling a new facility in 2010 for NZAC members, under which they will be entitled to reciprocal rights (members' fees) at huts and refuges in the Alps, the Pyrenees and other mountain areas such as the Dolomites and Picos de Europa. This would apply to literally thousands of huts managed by the Swiss, Austrian, French, Italian and German Alpine Clubs and the Spanish Mountaineering Federation.

Hut fees in Europe are expensive, not least because the facilities are distinctly more luxurious than in NZ huts. Currently NZAC members are not entitled to discounts at these huts. The fact that NZAC is a member of UIAA (World Mountaineering Federation) cuts no ice. Very occasionally, reduced fees are given by generous hut managers on presentation of a current NZAC card but that's good luck and unwise to rely on.

For those staying in huts for more than a few nights buying a reciprocity stamp through the Club, which will be attached to the NZAC membership card, will result in substantial savings on hut fees and, in some cases, reductions in the price of meals served at the huts.

Under the European agreement NZAC has been granted the right to issue these stamps in conjunction with the clubs and federations named above. The question is whether there will be enough interest to justify NZAC setting up this facility. Based on current rates of exchange the costs of a reciprocity stamp for a calendar year to an NZAC member is likely to be between NZ \$80 and NZ \$95.

We would like to get an indication of the likely interest from members in this scheme. Without any commitment on your part, please indicate whether you are likely to be interested in obtaining a reciprocity stamp for Europe for next year (2010) by emailing or calling John Nankervis (NZAC's current UIAA rep). John would welcome any other comments on the proposal.

Email john.nankervis@buddlefindlay.com or phone (04) 3850415 (H).



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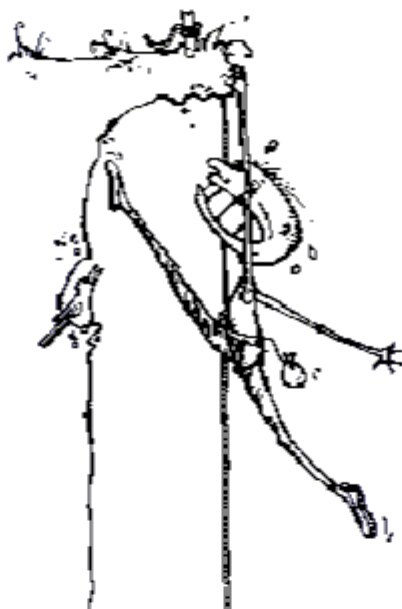
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Vice Chair	Vacant	vicechair	
Secretary	Catherine Moger	secretary or CM2	04 973 1307 (h) 021 079 0854
Acting Treasurer	Richard Davies	Treasurer	
National Rep	James Wright	JW	027 472 5561
Instruction Convenor	Scott Taylor	ST	
Trips	Kevin Patterson	Trips or KP	04 934 0975 (h) 027 687 9573
Other Committee Members	Richard Davies	RD	
	Scott Taylor	ST	
	ShiChang Hou	SH	
	Steve Minchin	SM	
	Max Gough	MG	
	Hinrich Schaefer		
	Rebecca Thomson		
Other Roles:			
Gear	Blair Hiscoke	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	Kevin Patterson	PLB or KP	
Instruction - AIC	Don French	AIC or DF	06 3777 117 (h) 027 445 2980
Instruction - Rock	Blair Hiscoke	summerrock or BH	
Library	Derek Richardson	library	
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	
Newsletter Editor	Steve Minchin	newsletter or SM	
Rock Drill overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	Richard Thomson	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
National Executive Officer	Ollie Clifton	ollie@alpineclub.org.nz	03 3777 595



If undelivered please return to:

NZAC Wellington Section
PO Box 1628
Wellington

